

Portfolio Website Design Guide

Danny Driscoll · Version 2.0 · March 2026

Active branch: design-v2 · Framework: Next.js 16.1.6, Tailwind CSS v4, React 19

01. Brand Colors

The brand palette is defined in the `@theme` inline block inside `app/globals.css`. This is the single source of truth. Never edit `tailwind.config.ts`.

Royal Blue	#3B5CE8 — primary accent, stat numbers, interactive links, skill badges
Charcoal	#606060 — secondary text, muted labels
Off-white	#F2F2F2 — light mode secondary background
Coral	#F47060 — focus rings, active nav underline indicator
Pink	#E0006E — case study accent (college app)
Amber	#F5C200 — case study accent (messaging API)
Tan	#D4BC8A — supporting warm accent
Magenta	#FF00AA — supporting vivid accent

02. Typography

Display font	Plus Jakarta Sans (--font-jakarta) — headings, nav wordmark, hero
Body font	Inter (--font-inter) — body copy, labels, captions
Scale source	@theme inline in globals.css — --text-display through --text-label
Display	4.5rem / 72px, weight 700, tracking -0.03em
H1	2.5rem / 40px, weight 700, tracking -0.02em
H2	1.875rem / 30px, weight 600, tracking -0.01em
H3	1.375rem / 22px, weight 600
Lead	1.25rem / 20px, line-height 1.6
Body	1rem / 16px, line-height 1.65
Small	0.875rem / 14px
Label	0.75rem / 12px, tracking 0.08em, weight 600

03. Dark Mode System

Dark mode uses `[data-theme="dark"]` attribute selectors on the `<html>` element. Never use Tailwind dark: utility classes — they are silently ignored in this project.

Light mode	:root CSS variables in globals.css — <code>--color-bg: #FFFFFF</code> , <code>--color-text-primary: #1A1A1A</code>
Dark mode	<code>[data-theme="dark"]</code> overrides in globals.css — <code>--color-bg: #0A0A0A</code> , <code>--color-text-primary: #F5F5F5</code>
Toggle	ThemeToggle component in Nav saves preference to localStorage. Light mode is the default.
Rule	All themeable elements must use CSS variables. Hardcoded Tailwind color utilities (bg-brand-offwhite, text-brand-charcoal) bypass the variable system and break dark mode.

04. Link Treatment — Rule of Three

Every interactive link must communicate interactivity through three simultaneous visual signals. Color alone fails colorblind users and violates WCAG 1.4.1.

Signal 1 — Color	#3B5CE8 royal blue on all links
Signal 2 — Underline	text-decoration: underline, text-decoration-offset: 3px, text-decoration-thickness: 1px
Signal 3 — Chevron	SVG arrow icon (12x12px) to the right of link text, same arrow as Resume button in Nav
Scope	Applies sitewide to all anchor tags across every page
Exception	Navigation links in the Nav component are exempt (they have active/hover states instead)

The Rule of Three — Danny's Core Visual Philosophy

Every differentiated or interactive element must have three things that are visually different. This could be color, size, font weight, shape, or character. Examples:

- Links: color + underline + chevron
 - Section differentiation: color + size + weight
 - Card categories: color + shape + position
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05. Eyebrow Labels

Section eyebrow labels are small uppercase tracking text that introduce sections. These must use `var(--color-text-secondary)`, not `#3B5CE8`.

Style	text-sm font-semibold tracking-widest uppercase
Color	<code>var(--color-text-secondary)</code> — <code>#606060</code> light / <code>#9CA3AF</code> dark
Why not blue	<code>#3B5CE8</code> on dark backgrounds fails WCAG AA at small sizes (~3.8:1 contrast). Blue is reserved for larger interactive elements where size compensates.
Blue reserved for	Stat numbers, interactive links, skill badge pills, active nav underline

06. Component Patterns

Skill Transfer Cards (About Page — Beyond the Work)

CSS class	<code>.about-card</code>
Light mode	<code>bg: var(--color-bg-card), border: 1px solid rgba(0,0,0,0.10), border-radius: 8px</code>
Dark mode	<code>bg: var(--color-bg-card), border: 1px solid rgba(255,255,255,0.10), border-radius: 8px</code>
Structure	Title + blue skill badge (pill) on same row, blue divider line, body text below
Skill badge	color: <code>#3B5CE8</code> , <code>bg: rgba(59,92,232,0.08)</code> , CSS class: <code>.skill-badge</code>

Philosophy Cards (Homepage)

CSS class	<code>.philosophy-card</code>
Light mode	<code>bg: rgba(255,255,255,0.25), backdrop-filter: blur(16px) saturate(180%), border: rgba(255,255,255,0.9)</code>
Dark mode	<code>bg: rgba(255,255,255,0.04), backdrop-filter: blur(16px) saturate(180%), border: rgba(255,255,255,0.12)</code>
Context	Sits on animated gradient background — glassmorphism only works on colored/textured backgrounds

Stat Numbers

Color	<code>#3B5CE8</code> (blue) — one of the approved uses of blue
Size	text-3xl font-bold

Attribution	Small caps uppercase below label: AT TELESIGN / AT CAPPEX / TELESIGN + CAPPEX
Unicode arrow	67 → 35 uses U+2192 right arrow — never replace with ASCII -> or HTML entity

07. Page Inventory

Homepage /	COMPLETE — nav, hero, stats, case study cards, origin story, philosophy, footer
Work /work	COMPLETE — dark mode fix applied
About /about	COMPLETE — bio, stats, skill cards, things you didn't ask about, videos, photography teaser
Photography /photography	COMPLETE — Empathique, Carl photo, grid, Papa Carl quote, light/dark mode
Contact /contact	TODO — not yet built
Case study /work/self-service-portal	PARTIAL — hero present, body sections present
Case study /work/fraud-prevention	PARTIAL — hero at 0% 60%, body sections present
Case study /work/messaging-api	PARTIAL — all image paths fixed
Case study /work/universal-college-app	PARTIAL — all paths confirmed

08. Technical Rules

Theme config	tailwind.config.ts is ignored. All tokens live in @theme inline in app/globals.css only.
Single @theme block	Only one @theme inline block must exist. Never add a second one.
Border radius	--radius-sm: 0.0625rem through --radius-2xl: 0.5rem. Half the original values.
File edits	Never use sed. Python string replacement only. Always cat file before writing.
Template literals	Backticks in Python heredocs must be actual characters, never escaped. Grep-verify after write.
Image rendering	Use unoptimized prop on Next.js Image for large files. herolmagePosition optional, defaults to center center.

Turbopack cache	Only restart (rm -rf .next) when switching branches or after Turbopack panic.
Nav location	components/layout/Nav.tsx — NOT app/components/
Footer location	components/layout/Footer.tsx — NOT app/components/

09. Navigation

Items	Work / About / Photography / Contact / Resume (external PDF link)
Active state	Coral underline (#F47060) below active item, text-primary color
Focus rings	#F47060 coral on all interactive elements
Mobile	Hamburger drawer, max-h transition animation
Sticky	Fixed top-0, backdrop-blur-md, border appears on scroll

10. Next Priorities

- Implement three-signal link treatment sitewide (color + underline + chevron)
- Fix eyebrow labels sitewide: blue → var(--color-text-secondary)
- Add Photography to footer navigation
- Build Contact page
- Build four case study pages (Self-Service Portal first)
- Netlify deployment